

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE

A Novelization

By

Wade Wilson

(Ghostwritten by The Chimichanga Team)

Based on the Motion Picture

BOOK I: THE ANCHOR

PROLOGUE: BYE BYE BYE

The ground was frozen. Not just cold—*frozen*. Like the heart of a Disney executive when you ask for an R-rating.

I slammed the shovel into the North Dakota permafrost. It made a sound like a gunshot wrapped in a wet towel. *Thwack-crunch.* My shoulders burned. My back screamed. My healing factor was working overtime, knitting torn muscle fibers back together just so I could tear them again with the next swing.

It's been a while since I did any manual labor that didn't involve disposing of bodies. Actually, this involves a body. Just... reverse disposing. Exhuming? Is that the word? Sounds fancy. Like a perfume that smells like old people.

I wiped sweat from my brow, smearing dirt across the mask. It smelled of pine needles, squirrel shit, and the looming specter of copyright infringement.

"Come on, Wolvie." I stabbed the earth again. "Don't be shy."

The grave of James Howlett. Logan. The Wolverine. The man who died saving a bunch of kids because he was just that kind of grumpy, self-sacrificing prick. I needed him. I needed the Anchor Being. I needed the guy who could help me save my world from getting pruned faster than a bonsai tree in a bored gardener's hands.

Clang.

Metal on metal. The sound vibrated up the shovel handle and rattled my teeth.

"Jackpot."

I tossed the shovel aside and fell to my knees, clawing at the dirt with gloved hands. I brushed away the soil until I saw it. The Adamantium coffin. Or, well, the box. Whatever.

"Okay, peanut. Time to wake up. We got work to do. We got a universe to save. We got—"

I pried the lid open. It shrieked, rusted hinges protesting the disturbance.

I looked inside.

And screamed.

Oh, come on. Really? You have got to be kidding me.

It wasn't a sleeping Wolverine. It wasn't a coma-napping Logan ready to pop his claws and say "Bub."

It was bones. Just... bones.

Shiny, metallic, indestructible bones. Ribs like the grill of a '58 Plymouth. A skull that seemed to be grinning at me, mocking my desperate, timeline-hopping stupidity.

"You died?" I asked the skeleton. "You actually died? In *Logan*? I thought that was just... artistic license! Oscar bait! You're Wolverine! You regenerate! You don't just—" I poked the skull.

"*Decompose.*"

I sat back on my heels, the cold seeping into my suit. *Well, Wade. You promised Vanessa. You promised the TVA guy—well, you headbutted him, but the sentiment was there. And now? Now you're sitting in a hole in the ground with a pile of very expensive scrap metal.*

"Freeze!"

The voice came from above. Mechanical. Amplified.

I looked up.

TVA Minutemen. A dozen of them. Standing on the rim of the grave, those little glow-sticks aimed right at my face. Pruning batons. The "Delete Key" of the multiverse.

"Wade Wilson." The lead agent raised his baton, the tip glowing with erasure energy. "Step away from the deceased Variant."

I looked at the agents. I looked at the skeleton.

Okay. Plan B. Or maybe Plan C. I've lost track.

I stood up, brushing dirt from my knees. "You guys. You picked a really bad time. I'm grieving here. This is my emotional support skeleton."

"Prune him," the agent ordered.

Music cue. Something poppy. Something that says 'I'm about to murder all of you with a dead guy's limbs'.

I reached down and grabbed the Adamantium femur. It was heavy. Dense. Balanced perfectly for blunt force trauma.

"Hit it," I whispered to the non-existent DJ in my head.

BYE BYE BYE START

I launched myself out of the grave.

The first agent didn't even see it coming. I swung the leg bone like a baseball bat. *CRACK.* His

helmet shattered. The sound was wet—like dropping a melon on concrete. He folded, his body shutting down instantly.

Ooh. That felt good. That felt... resonant.

Two more rushed me. I ducked a glowing baton that sizzled the air where my ear used to be (before the cancer took it, anyway). I spun, driving the sharp end of the femur into the second guy's gut. The Adamantium didn't give. His armor did. He gasped, falling to his knees, wheezing like a pug with asthma.

Left swing. Right swing. Pirouette.

I was dancing. I was a beautiful, red-and-black ballerina of death, and my partner was a piece of the X-Men's most popular merchandise.

I jammed the skull onto a guy's head like a helmet, then punched it. *BONG.* He went down.

"I! Want! To! Be! With! You!" I sang, synchronizing the punches to the beat that only I could hear.

Another agent lunged. I grabbed Logan's claws—still attached to the hand bones—and *SNIKT*. I didn't have the muscles to pop them, but I could manually deploy the stabby bits.

I raked them across the agent's chest. Sparks flew. Armor parted like tissue paper. Blood sprayed, hot and copper-smelling in the freezing air. It misted on my mask. I tasted it through the fabric—salty, metallic.

This is it. This is the stuff. The physics of violence. It's not clean. It's messy. It's exhausting.

My breath was coming in ragged gasps. The suit was tight in the crotch. My heart hammered against my ribs like a prisoner demanding parole.

"I'm doing this for you, peanut!" I yelled at the scattered bones. "Don't think I don't appreciate the loan!"

I backflipped off a tree stump, landing on another agent's shoulders. I drove the leg bone down. *Crunch.* Collarbone. Goodbye.

The snow around the grave was turning red. A slushy, bloody mess. Steam rose from the fresh kills.

God, I love this job.

"Is that all of you?" I panted, standing amidst the carnage, holding the Adamantium claws in a dual-wield stance that looked cool as hell but was practically useless.

A portal opened. Orange. Rectangular.

More agents poured out.

Oh, good. The sequel.

I cracked my neck.

"Maximum effort." And then, because I couldn't help myself, I added, "And somebody check on the box office tracking. I think we just secured the opening weekend."

CHAPTER 1: THE COMMUTE

The air in the showroom smelled of stale coffee, floor wax, and the desperate optimism of sub-prime lending. It was a specific cocktail of scents, one that coated the back of Wade Wilson's throat like a film of cheap grease.

He adjusted his tie. It was a polyester monstrosity, wide enough to land a plane on, patterned with little sailboats that seemed to be sinking. It was the kind of tie a man wore when he had given up on being a superhero and decided that his true calling was moving mid-sized family vehicles with best-in-class safety ratings.

"So." The customer shifted his weight, testing the floor tiles with his heels. He was a man in his forties, soft around the middle, wearing a polo shirt that was tucked in aggressively tight. "Does it have the... you know?"

He made a vague hand gesture that could have meant anything from heated seats to a portal to the dark dimension.

Wade smiled. It was the smile he had practiced in the mirror for six weeks. The 'I am a trustworthy human being with a pulse and a credit score' smile. It hurt his face. Underneath the wig—a masterful piece of toupee engineering that sat on his scarred scalp like a nervous badger—his skin felt tight.

"The sliding doors?" Wade asked, voice smooth, devoid of the manic rasp that usually accompanied a katana swing. "Sir, let me tell you about the Carnival. It doesn't just have sliding doors. It has *automatic smart-power* sliding doors. You approach the vehicle with the key fob in your pocket? Boom. Sesame opens. No hands required. Because let's be honest, your hands are full. Groceries. Screaming children. The crushing weight of existence."

The customer blinked. "Right. The kids."

"Exactly." Wade patted the hood of the white minivan. It rang hollow, a tinny sound that echoed in the cavernous dealership. "Look at this bad boy. V6 engine. ample cargo space. You could fit... well, you could fit a lot of soccer equipment in here. Or lumber. Or, hypothetically, if you were a different kind of person, which you aren't, several duffel bags of non-sequential bills."

The man laughed nervously. "Funny guy."

Wade leaned back against the minivan. "I try." The humor felt dry in his mouth. Ashy.

This is it. This is the dream.

He looked out the plate glass window. The world outside was grey. Rain drizzled on the asphalt, turning the parking lot into a watercolor painting of misery. No explosions. No ninjas. No time-traveling cyborgs trying to kill a kid. Just cars. Just the endless, grinding cycle of commerce.

His wrist itched.

Not the skin. The bone. The place where the scars ran deepest, where the cancer had chewed on him like a dog with a bone. He rubbed it absentmindedly, feeling the lumpy texture through the cheap fabric of his suit jacket.

"Wade!"

The shout came from the manager's office. Gary. Or was it Larry? It was definitely a name that ended in a vowel sound that implied disappointment.

"Excuse me one moment." Wade pushed off the van. "Browse the infotainment system. It has Apple CarPlay. It will change your life. Or at least distract you from it."

He walked across the showroom floor. His loafers squeaked. *Squeak. Squeak. Squeak.*

The office was a glass box in the corner. A fishbowl for the big fish to watch the little fish swim in circles. Gary-Larry was sitting behind a desk that was too big for the room, staring at a spreadsheet.

"Wilson." He didn't look up. "Your numbers."

"Stellar? Astronomical? Defying the laws of physics?"

"Adequate." Gary-Larry looked up. He had eyes like a dead cod. "You sold the Honda Odyssey last week. That was good. But you're lagging on the upsells. The extended warranties. The undercoating."

"The undercoating is a scam, Gary," Wade said. "It's literally just spray paint and lies."

"It's *peace of mind*," Gary corrected. "And it's margin. We need margin, Wilson. You want to keep this job? You want to keep playing... whatever character this is?" He gestured vaguely at Wade's face. "Then sell the rust protection."

Wade stared at him.

For a second—just a microsecond—the world tilted.

He saw it. He saw the red targeting reticle over Gary's forehead. He saw the trajectory of a staple gun from the desk. He saw the cinematic slow-motion sequence where he vaulted the desk, kicked the ergonomic chair through the window, and rode the coffee machine into the sunset.

Do it, the voice in his head whispered. *Just a little maiming. As a treat.*

Wade swallowed. He forced the smile back onto his face. He locked the reticle away. He put the staple gun back in the drawer of his mind.

"Rust protection," Wade said. "Got it. Rust never sleeps. Neither do I. We're birds of a feather."

"Get back out there," Gary said, dismissing him with a wave.

Wade walked out.

He went to the break room. He poured a cup of coffee that had been sitting on the burner since the Carter administration. It tasted like burnt rubber and regret.

He leaned against the counter and closed his eyes.

He touched the locket under his shirt. The picture of Vanessa.

I promised, he thought. *No more chaos. No more violence. Just Wade. Just... this.*

He took a sip of the coffee.

It scalded his tongue.

"Ow," he whispered.

He opened his eyes. He looked at his reflection in the microwave door. The wig was slightly askew.

"You look great," he told the blurry reflection. "You look like a million bucks. Adjusted for inflation."

He straightened his tie. He walked back out to the floor.

"Sir!" he called out to the customer, his voice booming with forced cheer. "Let's talk about floor mats! You're gonna want the all-weather ones. Trust me. Life gets messy."

CHAPTER 2: A VERY WILSONS BIRTHDAY

The apartment smelled of cheap tequila, taco seasoning, and that specific, humid musk of too many bodies crammed into a space designed for two. It was a happy smell, theoretically. It was the smell of friendship. Of celebration. Of life continuing, despite everything.

Wade stood in the center of the room, holding a paper plate that was rapidly losing its structural integrity under the weight of a chimichanga.

"Surprise!" they had yelled.

And he had acted surprised. He had done the face—the widening of the eyes, the hand over the chest. He was good at acting. He'd been acting for years.

Blind Al was sitting on the couch, arguing with Peter about the viscosity of the guacamole.

"It's too chunky, Peter!" she shouted, waving a chip like a dagger. "It's like dipping a chip into a salad! I want paste! I want green sludge!"

"It's rustic, Al!" Peter beamed, his mustache quivering with wholesome delight. "It's artisanal!"

Wade looked around the room.

There was Dopinder, chatting up a girl who looked terrified. There was Negasonic, looking bored and fierce, tapping away on her phone like she was ordering a drone strike on the party. There was Yukio, radiating pink energy and genuine joy. There was Colossus, stooping to avoid hitting his head on the ceiling fan, holding a tiny red cup that looked like a thimble in his metallic hand.

And there was Vanessa.

She was by the window, laughing at something Buck said. The light from the streetlamp outside caught her hair, turning it into a halo of dark silk. She looked... radiant. Normal. Happy.

Wade felt a crack in his chest. A fissure running right down the center of his sternum.

You don't belong here, the thought whispered. It sounded like Stephen King reading an audiobook of his own suicide note. *Look at them. They're real. They're solid. You? You're a cartoon character

drawn by a shaky hand.*

He took a bite of the chimichanga. It was cold in the middle.

"Wade!"

Vanessa saw him. She waved him over.

He walked toward her. The floorboards creaked under his feet—a sound he knew well. *Eeee-errrk.* The sound of home. Or at least, the sound of the place where he kept his stuff.

"Hey." He slid his arm around her waist. It felt natural, yet foreign. Like wearing a glove on the wrong hand. "Great party. Who invited the giant metal Russian? I thought we had a weight limit on the floor joists."

"Be nice." She poked him in the ribs. "He brought vodka. Good vodka. Not the stuff you buy in plastic jugs."

Wade shrugged. "I like the plastic jugs. They bounce when you drop them."

She looked at him. Really looked at him. Her eyes were dark pools, deep enough to drown in. "Are you okay, Wade?"

"Me? I'm fantastic. I'm the birthday boy. I'm... I'm just soaking it in."

"You seem... quiet."

"Quiet is my middle name. Wade Quiet Wilson. It's on my birth certificate. Or it would be, if I hadn't used it to light a cigar in 1998."

She touched his cheek. Her hand was warm. His skin—scarred, lumpy, hideous—burned under her touch. Not with pain, but with shame.

She sees you, the voice narrated. *She sees the monster under the wig. She sees the tumor with legs.*

She leaned closer, her breath warm against his ear. "I miss you."

Wade squeezed her waist. "I'm right here."

"Are you?"

The question hung in the air, heavier than Colossus.

Wade opened his mouth to answer with a joke. A deflection. A reference to *The Great British Bake Off*. But the words died in his throat.

Because she was right. He wasn't there. He was somewhere else. He was back in the grave, digging up bones. He was back in the dealership, selling lies. He was floating in the space between panels, waiting for the writer to decide what happened next.

"I'm trying," he said, and for the first time all night, it was the truth. "I'm trying so hard, Ness."

"I know," she said. She leaned in and kissed him. It was soft. Sweet. And it tasted like goodbye.

Someone knocked on the door.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Three sharp raps. Precise. Authoritative. Not the knock of a neighbor complaining about the noise. Not the knock of a pizza delivery guy.

This was the knock of Plot.

The room went quiet.

"I'll get it." Wade pulled away from Vanessa. He felt a sudden chill, a premonition that prickled the hairs on the back of his neck (the few that were left).

He walked to the door. He put his hand on the knob. The metal was cold.

Don't open it, the voice said. *If you open it, the genre changes. If you open it, the horror starts.*

Wade opened the door.

[TO BE CONTINUED IN CHAPTER 3: THE KNOCK]

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